OBSERVABILITY · BUDGET REQUEST

The case for Grafana + Prometheus

Product and client environments run with no centralized monitoring today. This paper requests budget to fix that.

The problem

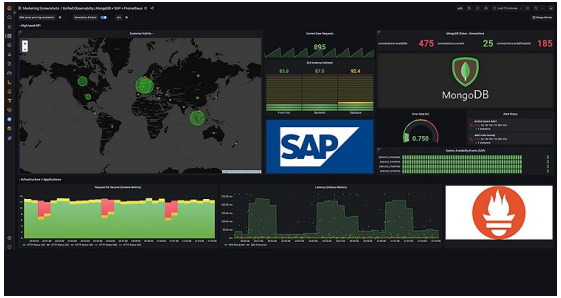
No dashboards, no alerting, no historical view – issues surface from customers, not from us.

The proposal

Stand up a self-hosted Grafana + Prometheus stack across product and client environments.

The ask

Approve a small recurring infra budget to host the stack (the software itself is free).







SCENE SETTING

Growing footprint, no visibility

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Scaling across product and client environments has outgrown manual checks and after-the-fact fixes.

TODAY

- Reactive: we find out from a customer or a support ticket
- Logs scattered across servers, checked manually
- No dashboards – every health check is a person, not a system
- No alerting – nobody is paged before customers notice

WITH GRAFANA + PROMETHEUS

- Proactive: alert rules page the right person automatically
- One time-series store for product and client environments
- Dashboards give a live, shared view of system health
- Historical data makes root-causing incidents faster

THE MECHANISM

Two tools, two distinct jobs

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Prometheus is the backend that collects and stores metrics. Grafana is the frontend that visualizes them.

PROMETHEUS – THE BACKEND

- Pull model: scrapes metrics from apps on an interval
- Stores everything itself as time-series data
- Queried with PromQL
- Handles deep infrastructure alerting

GRAFANA – THE FRONTEND

- Visualization layer – doesn't collect or store metrics itself
- Connects to many data sources: Prometheus, MySQL, Elasticsearch, and more
- Builds the drag-and-drop graphs and dashboards

Both tools are open source (Apache 2.0 / AGPL) and run today at companies of every size – proven, boring infrastructure, not a bet on a new vendor.

COST

What this actually costs

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The software is free. The ask is infrastructure to run it, sized for a small footprint (1–5 servers/services).

Software license

$0. Prometheus and Grafana OSS are both free, open-source software.

Hosting (estimate)

~$30–50/month for a small VM running both services, at this scale.

Storage (estimate)

~$5–10/month for a metrics retention volume, depending on retention window.

Setup time

Estimated 2–4 engineer-days to instrument services and build initial dashboards.

Ongoing upkeep

Estimated 2–3 hours/month – updates, dashboard tuning, alert-rule review.

Total (estimate)

Roughly $35–60/month in infra, plus a one-time setup cost. Ranges to be confirmed against actual cloud quotes.

! **Grafana Cloud's free tier (10k series, 14-day retention) may cover this footprint at $0 – worth checking before committing to self-hosted infra spend.**

ROLLOUT

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A phased rollout, starting small

Prove value on the current footprint before expanding coverage.

1 Instrument core services

Stand up Prometheus, connect it to the current 1–5 servers across product and client environments.

2 Build shared dashboards

Grafana dashboards for the metrics that matter most today – uptime, latency, error rates.

3 Turn on alerting

Alert rules for the incidents that currently reach us only through a customer.

CONCLUSION

Recommendation and ask

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A small, proven investment closes a real visibility gap before it costs a customer.

Build vs. buy

A custom monitoring build would cost engineering months. Grafana + Prometheus does it for ~$40/month in infra.

Proven at scale

This is the default observability stack for teams from small startups to large platforms – not an experimental choice.

The ask

~$35–$60/mo infra budget

Sign-off

CFO

! **Self-hosting means the team owns maintenance and uptime of the monitoring stack itself – budget the 2–3 hrs/month upkeep, or revisit Grafana Cloud if that overhead isn't worth taking on.**